



ACQLERATE

MODULE 6

Program Operations & Leadership

Lead programs effectively: risk management, stakeholder communications, subcontractor oversight, and career advancement.

6 Lessons · ~89 Minutes · Lesson Book Edition

Course Lessons

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PROGRAM OPERATIONS & LEADERSHIP · LESSON 1

Career Roadmap: Breaking Into DoD Acquisitions

12 min

Map both defense acquisition career tracks honestly, government and contractor, from entry point to the senior executive ranks.

Whether you're coming from a technical background, a business degree, or a military transition, defense acquisitions offers two very different career paths (government and contractor) with distinct entry points, credentials, and cultures. This lesson maps both tracks honestly: what each side actually does, how to get in the door, what gets you hired, what to expect in compensation, and how the career develops from entry level to the senior executive ranks.

KEY CONCEPT

A PM Is Not a Promotion

This is the most important concept in this lesson, and it's the one that trips people up most often.

Becoming a Program Manager is not a promotion from your current job. It's a lateral move into a completely different discipline.

Being a great engineer doesn't make you a great PM any more than being a great surgeon makes you a great hospital administrator. The skills are adjacent but different. One is about doing the work. The other is about making sure the work gets done: by the right people, at the right cost, on the right schedule.

The surgeon analogy is worth sitting with. A surgeon who becomes a department head and keeps trying to do surgery all day is a bad department head. The job changed. The measure of success changed. Everything that made them excellent before is now, at best, a distraction, and at worst, a liability (ask any surgeon who still insists on scrubbing in personally during the department budget meeting).

Defense PM is the same. The best engineers, analysts, and contract specialists who become PMs often struggle in the transition because they keep defaulting to doing the technical work instead of managing it. It feels productive to dive into the details. It feels uncomfortable to stay at 30,000 feet while problems pile up below you, and nobody issues you a parachute for that particular discomfort. But that discomfort is exactly the job.

A PM's core questions are: Who owns this? What are the options? What does leadership need to know, and when do they need to know it? Not: let me solve this myself.

If you're moving into a PM role, give yourself six months before you judge whether you're good at it. The rewiring takes time.

If You're Not in the People Business, Think Twice

What a Contractor PM Actually Leads

- Your people: not just their tasks
- The client relationship: not just the deliverables
- The program health: not just the schedule
- The culture: not just the deliverable quality

What PM Is Not

Not a revenue generator first. That's a BD job.

Not just a boss. Anyone can tell people what to do. A PM leads, which means setting direction, removing obstacles, and making the team better at their jobs.

Not a subject matter expert who manages. The PM's job is to make sure the right experts are working the right problems: not to be the smartest person in every technical conversation.

If your primary motivation for becoming a PM is the title, the pay bump, or the authority to direct people: find a different path. The PMs who last and leave a mark are the ones who are genuinely energized by the people and the mission. Everything else follows from that.

FROM LUCAS

Presence Is Power

A leader isn't a ghost, someone your team only hears from through email, phone calls, or a name typed at the bottom of a memo. If your people only know you that way, you're not leading them. You're haunting them.

Get out from behind the desk. Walk the floor. Show up to where the actual work happens, not just the reviews where the work gets reported on. This matters most in your first year as a PM, when your team is still quietly deciding whether you're actually in the people business or just passing through it on your way somewhere else. Presence is how they find out the answer is yes.

Getting In: Government Track

- Start your security clearance process immediately
- USAJOBS.gov is the only place government jobs are posted
- The Pathways Program is the best entry door for recent graduates
- DAU training is free for government employees: start now
- The defense community is small: network accordingly

- Your federal resume is not your private-sector resume
- Apply broadly and expect the process to take months

Getting In: Contractor Track

- The big firms are not the only option, and may not be the best for early careers
- Program Analyst is the most common entry-level door
- Get your PMP: even if you don't have it yet
- GovWin IQ is essential if you move into business development
- LinkedIn is how this industry actually hires
- A security clearance is more valuable than an extra degree at senior levels

What Actually Gets You Hired

Here's the honest version of what both sides are looking for: problem solvers, not task completers.

Anyone can say they “supported a program” or “managed acquisition actions.” The candidates who get hired (and get promoted) are the ones who can tell a specific story about a problem they diagnosed, a solution they built, and an outcome they drove.

This is what that sounds like in practice: “We were 18 months out from Milestone B (a major program review) and our schedule showed we were going to miss it. I identified the critical path issues early, built a recovery plan with three options, briefed leadership with a clear recommendation, and we made the milestone on time.”

That answer has: a problem, an analysis, a decision, and an outcome. It shows judgment, not just activity.

Certifications get you in the door. They signal baseline competence and show you took the time to invest in the field. But problem-solving keeps you in the room, and gets you the next job.

When you're preparing for interviews, build a library of five to seven specific stories like this from your own experience. Use the STAR format (Situation, Task, Action, Result) if it helps structure your thinking. The specific details (the program name, the dollar amount, the schedule date) are what make the story credible. Vague stories sound like resume filler. Specific stories sound like experience. Nobody has ever been hired for saying they “drove cross-functional synergy.”

Salary Reality Check (2025 Estimates)

TRACK	ROLE / GRADE	APPROXIMATE ANNUAL SALARY	NOTES
Government	GS-9 (Entry)	\$55,000 – \$72,000	Varies significantly by location; D.C. metro adds ~30%
Government	GS-11 (Early Career)	\$66,000 – \$87,000	Typical after 2–3 years; first supervisory roles possible
Government	GS-12 (Mid Career)	\$79,000 – \$103,000	Where most people spend several years building specialization
Government	GS-13 (Senior Specialist)	\$94,000 – \$122,000	Competitive; typically requires DAPA certification progress
Government	GS-14 (Senior PM / Lead)	\$111,000 – \$144,000	Major program experience usually required to reach this grade
Government	GS-15 (Principal / Director)	\$130,000 – \$169,000	Highest non-SES grade; leadership of significant programs
Contractor	Program Analyst (Entry)	\$65,000 – \$85,000	Wide range depending on firm size, clearance level, location
Contractor	Program Manager (Mid)	\$100,000 – \$135,000	With PMP and active clearance; direct program oversight
Contractor	Senior PM / Program Director	\$140,000 – \$185,000	TS/SCI + program relationships = primary value drivers
Contractor	VP, Business Development	\$180,000 – \$250,000+	Highly variable; often includes commission/bonus structure

FROM LUCAS**Mid-Career: Building a Portfolio, Not Just a Resume**

If you're five to ten years in and thinking about the next level, the question changes. It's no longer “how do I get experience?” It's “what kind of experience am I deliberately building?”

The most competitive GS-14 and GS-15 profiles (and the contractor equivalents) share a few characteristics. First, they've worked on at least one major program. In acquisition, program size is classified using ACAT levels (Acquisition Category). ACAT I programs are the big ones: major weapons systems with price tags in the billions that Congress watches closely and the Secretary of Defense approves. ACAT II programs are still significant but operate with more delegation. Having ACAT I or ACAT II experience on your resume signals that you understand how defense acquisition works at scale, with real stakes.

Second, they've done a functional rotation. The best PMs understand finance, contracting, and engineering: not at a practitioner level, but well enough to ask the right questions. A rotation through a contracting office or a program finance function makes you a materially better PM. It also demonstrates breadth of perspective, which is increasingly what senior hiring managers look for.

Third, they're current on their DAPA certifications. The government's certification framework isn't just a credential: it reflects the training requirements tied to specific job levels. Letting your certifications lag sends a signal that you're coasting.

For those considering the government-to-contractor transition: this typically happens at the GS-13 to GS-15 level, and it's worth thinking through clearly. Contractors aren't just paying for your PM skills: they're paying for your clearance, your knowledge of a specific program or customer office, and your relationships. Those things have genuine market value. The tradeoff is that you give up federal benefits, pension accrual, and some job stability. Neither choice is obviously better: it depends on what you're optimizing for. Just make the choice deliberately rather than because a recruiter caught you on a good day.

The Senior Executive Path

If you're thinking about SES (Senior Executive Service), the top of the civilian career ladder, you're playing a longer game, and the rules are different.

First, some scale: there are roughly 7,000 SES members across the entire federal government, out of a workforce of roughly two million civilians. The odds are not exactly in your favor, but nobody said the long game was supposed to be easy. In defense acquisition, the most visible senior civilian positions are Program Executive Officers (PEOs), the officials who oversee portfolios of related programs, and Deputy Assistant Secretaries of Defense. These are the civilian equivalents of general officers. Getting there requires two decades of deliberate choices, not just accumulated time.

Here's what the path actually requires:

- **Major Program Experience.** You need at least one tour as a PM or Deputy PM on a significant program: ideally ACAT I or II. This is non-negotiable. You cannot credibly lead a PEO's office if you haven't personally managed a program through at least one major milestone review.
- **Joint Duty Assignment (JDA).** This is a cross-service or cross-agency assignment: for example, an Army acquisition officer spending a tour at a Navy command, or a civilian working at a joint combatant command. JDAs are required by law for senior civilian positions in the defense department. They're also genuinely valuable: working outside your home service gives you a network and a perspective that's rare.
- **Senior Service College.** Army War College, Naval War College, Air War College: the war colleges admit senior civilians alongside senior military officers. This is not optional for the SES track, and the curriculum isn't really the point. The relationships you build in that year (with future generals, admirals, and senior executives) matter more than the coursework. Plan for this in your mid-40s.
- **Candidate Development Program (CDP).** Most military departments run CDPs for civilians who want to be considered for SES. These are competitive programs: apply three to five years before you want the role. They involve developmental assignments, executive coaching, and formal assessment. If SES is your goal, identify the CDP in your organization and start positioning for it early.

The plain-English reality check: this path takes 20 or more years and requires deliberate choices starting from your first program assignment. Random assignments produce random careers. If you want to lead a major program office someday, that goal should inform which jobs you take at GS-12 and GS-13: not just at GS-14 and GS-15. The people who make SES didn't stumble into it. They planned backward from where they wanted to be.

Key Terms

GS Scale (General Schedule)

The federal government's standard pay system, running from GS-1 (entry level) to GS-15 (senior professional). Most acquisition careers start at GS-7 or GS-9 and top out around GS-14 or GS-15 before the Senior Executive Service. The grade determines your salary band, which varies by location: working in Washington D.C. pays more than the same grade in a lower cost-of-living city.

Program Manager (PM)

The person accountable for delivering a defense program: on schedule, within budget, and to the required performance. Critically: the PM is not the technical expert. The PM's job is coordination, decision-making, and accountability. They make sure the right people are working the right problems and that leadership always has what they need to make informed decisions.

Defense Contractor

A private company that is paid by the government to deliver goods or services: weapons systems, software, logistics support, advisory services, and much more. Major players include Lockheed Martin, Raytheon, Boeing, Booz Allen Hamilton, Leidos, and SAIC. Contractors do the technical work; government employees oversee it and are ultimately accountable for outcomes.

Security Clearance

Official authorization from the U.S. government to access classified information. The most common levels are Secret and Top Secret (with TS/SCI (Sensitive Compartmented Information) being the most demanding). Getting cleared takes 6 to 18 months on average and involves a detailed background investigation. In this industry, having a clearance is often worth more than an extra degree: it's genuinely hard to replace.

DAU (Defense Acquisition University)

Yes, another “Defense” hiding in the name; we won't pretend that pun isn't sitting right there. The federal government's training institution for acquisition professionals. It offers hundreds of courses (most of them free to government employees) covering contracting, program management, finance, logistics, and more. If you're on the government track, DAU isn't optional. Start with ACQ 101 (Fundamentals of Systems Acquisition Management), which is free and available online.

Series 1102 / 1101 (Job Series Codes)

Federal job classification codes used to categorize acquisition roles. Series 1102 is the Contracting Specialist / Contracting Officer track: the people who write and award contracts. Series 1101 is a broader Program Management / Acquisition Support category. When searching USAJOBS.gov, filtering by these series codes is the fastest way to find acquisition jobs and cuts through the noise.

Pathways Program

The federal government's structured entry-level hiring program for recent college graduates (within the past two years). It's the most direct door into a government acquisition career without prior federal experience. Most positions are GS-7 to GS-9, include a formal development plan, and can convert to a full-time permanent position after one year. Think of it as a paid apprenticeship with a built-in career track.

PMP (Project Management Professional)

The most widely recognized project management certification in the world, administered by PMI (Project Management Institute). On the contractor side, it's essentially a baseline credential for anyone in a PM or program analyst role. It signals that you understand the discipline of project management (scheduling, risk, stakeholder management) regardless of what industry you learned it in.

GovWin IQ

A business intelligence platform used extensively by defense contractors to track government opportunities, monitor competitor activity, and plan business development strategy. If you end up in a Business Development (BD) or capture role on the contractor side, GovWin is the primary tool for finding and qualifying new contract opportunities before they're officially solicited.

DAPA (Defense Acquisition Professional Development Program)

The current framework (formerly called DAWIA: Defense Acquisition Workforce Improvement Act, which means this one definition alone has “Defense” in it twice) that defines certification requirements for government acquisition professionals. It establishes what training, education, and experience you need to hold certain positions. Working toward your certifications isn't bureaucratic box-checking: it's the clearest signal to hiring managers that you're serious about this career.

Knowledge Check

What is the most accurate way to describe the difference between working on the government side versus the contractor side in defense acquisition?

A. Government employees do the technical work; contractors oversee it

✓ **B. Government employees are the client with oversight authority; contractors are the vendors who deliver the work**

C. Both sides perform the same functions but are paid differently

D. Contractors have more authority because they hold the technical expertise

WHY

The government side functions as the client: setting requirements, controlling funds, and maintaining oversight authority. The contractor side functions as the vendor: executing the work and being measured on schedule, cost, and performance. Many professionals move between the two sides over the course of a career because understanding both perspectives is genuinely valuable.

A talented systems engineer with 10 years of experience is considering a move into a Program Manager role. What is the most important thing for them to understand about this transition?

- A. Their technical expertise will be their biggest advantage as a PM
- B. The PM role is a natural promotion that rewards deep technical expertise

✓ C. PM is a different job focused on coordination and accountability, not technical execution

- D. The main challenge will be learning acquisition regulations

WHY

The PM role requires a fundamentally different mindset: Who owns this? What are the options? What does leadership need to know? The best engineers who become PMs often struggle initially because they keep defaulting to doing the technical work instead of managing it. The job is coordination and accountability; not expertise.

A recent college graduate (graduated 14 months ago) wants to start a career on the government side of defense acquisition. What is the best entry path?

- A. Apply directly to GS-12 positions using USAJOBS.gov

✓ B. The Pathways Recent Graduates Program, which offers GS-7 to GS-9 positions with a structured development plan

- C. Start at a defense contractor first and then transition to government after two years
- D. Wait until you have a security clearance before applying

WHY

The Pathways Recent Graduates Program is the primary federal government entry mechanism for recent college graduates. It offers positions typically at GS-7 to GS-9, a one-year development program, and conversion to a permanent appointment; all without requiring prior federal experience.

Which certification is considered a baseline credential for contractor Program Manager roles and is widely required rather than preferred?

- A. DAPA Level III certification

✓ B. PMP (Project Management Professional)

- C. DAU ACQ 101 completion certificate
- D. TS/SCI security clearance

WHY

The PMP (Project Management Professional), administered by PMI, is the standard baseline certification for contractor PM roles. It's recognized across industries and demonstrates structured project management competence. If you don't have it yet, it should be on your roadmap from the start of your contractor career.

How does a security clearance most directly affect a defense acquisition career, especially at senior levels?

- A. It primarily affects which DAU courses you can take
- B. It has little practical impact since most acquisition work is unclassified

✓ **C. It is a critical asset: cleared professionals have access to classified programs and are substantially more valuable, especially to contractors**

- D. It only matters for government employees, not contractors

WHY

A security clearance is a genuine career asset in defense acquisition: treat it like one. At senior levels, your clearance and your program relationships are often what contractors are actually paying for. The clearance process takes 6 to 18 months minimum, so starting it early and protecting it throughout your career is critical.

What do job series codes like 1102 and 1101 mean when searching for federal acquisition jobs?

- A. They are security classification levels for acquisition programs
- B. They are DAU certification levels for program managers

✓ **C. They are federal job classification codes: 1102 covers Contracting Specialist and KO positions, 1101 covers Program Management and Acquisition Support roles**

- D. They identify the GS pay grade range for entry-level acquisition jobs

WHY

Series codes are the federal government's job classification system. Series 1102 covers Contracting Specialist and KO positions; Series 1101 covers broader Program Management and Acquisition Support roles. When searching USAJOBS.gov, using these series codes as filters is the fastest way to surface acquisition-specific positions.

What does DAU (Defense Acquisition University) provide, and what does it cost government employees?

- A. Advanced degree programs in defense management; tuition varies by program

✓ **B. A wide range of acquisition training courses that are free for government employees**

- C. Contractor-focused PMP preparation; fees apply for all participants
- D. Security clearance processing and adjudication support

WHY

DAU provides comprehensive acquisition training (free for government employees) covering every major acquisition discipline. ACQ 101 (Fundamentals of Systems Acquisition Management) is the recommended starting point. DAU courses are tied to DAPA certification requirements, so completing them isn't just professional development: it's career progression.

When a defense contractor recruits a senior government acquisition professional, what are they primarily paying for?

A. Their academic credentials and graduate degrees

B. Their DAU certification levels

✓ C. Their security clearance, knowledge of specific programs, and relationships with the customer organization

D. Their ability to write acquisition regulations

WHY

When a contractor recruits a senior government professional, they're primarily acquiring three things: an active security clearance (which cannot be quickly replicated), deep knowledge of a specific program or customer office, and existing relationships with the government personnel who will make or influence procurement decisions. That package is what drives the salary premium in government-to-contractor transitions.

What is GovWin IQ primarily used for in the defense contractor world?

A. Processing security clearance applications for contractor employees

B. Submitting contract proposals through the government procurement portal

✓ C. Tracking government procurement opportunities, monitoring competitor wins, and planning business development strategy

D. Managing program schedules and deliverables for active contracts

WHY

GovWin IQ is a business intelligence platform that tracks the federal procurement market: upcoming solicitations, historical awards, competitor activity, and agency spending trends. It's the go-to tool for contractor business development and capture teams, and basic familiarity with it signals to employers that you understand how the contractor business development process works.

Based on typical 2025 salary ranges, approximately how much of a salary increase might a GS-14 government acquisition professional expect when transitioning to a Senior PM or Program Director role at a defense contractor?

A. Little to no increase: government and contractor salaries are comparable at senior levels

✓ B. Approximately 25–50% increase, moving from roughly \$111–144K to \$140–185K

C. A decrease in total compensation due to the loss of federal benefits

D. More than double the salary in all cases

WHY

The salary premium for transitioning from a GS-14 government role to a comparable senior contractor position is typically 25 to 50 percent in base salary. The tradeoff is real though: federal benefits, pension accrual, and job stability have genuine financial value. A government-to-contractor transition at GS-13 to GS-15 level makes financial sense for many professionals, but it should be a deliberate choice, not a reactive one.

PROGRAM OPERATIONS & LEADERSHIP · LESSON 2

Risk Management in Defense Programs

14 min

Build and execute a rigorous risk management program that prevents problems before they become crises.

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5×5 Risk Matrix: DoD Standard (Score = Probability × Impact)

PROBABILITY ↓ / IMPACT →	IMPACT 1 (MINIMAL)	IMPACT 2 (MINOR)	IMPACT 3 (MODERATE)	IMPACT 4 (SIGNIFICANT)	IMPACT 5 (CRITICAL)
P=5 Near Certain (>80%)	5, MED	10, HIGH	15, HIGH	20, HIGH	25, HIGH
P=4 Likely (61– 80%)	4, MED	8, MED	12, HIGH	16, HIGH	20, HIGH
P=3 Possible (41– 60%)	3, LOW	6, MED	9, MED	12, HIGH	15, HIGH
P=2 Unlikely (21– 40%)	2, LOW	4, LOW	6, MED	8, MED	10, HIGH
P=1 Remote (≤20%)	1, LOW	2, LOW	3, LOW	4, MED	5, MED

Reading the Matrix: Real Program Examples

GREEN (Low, 1–4): Monitor only: log in risk register, review quarterly. Example: mild weather delay on an outdoor test range (nature, refusing to read the schedule as usual). **YELLOW (Medium, 5–9):** Develop mitigation plan with assigned owner and due date. Example: single-source supplier for a critical subcomponent. **RED (High, 10–25):** Immediate PM attention: active mitigation, management reserve may be needed, brief MDA at next program review. Example: key technology not yet at TRL 6 entering EMD, or contractor staffing 20% below plan on critical path tasks.

Sample Risk Register: Active Program Risks

RISK ID	DESCRIPTION	P / I / SCORE	LEVEL	MITIGATION	OWNER
R-001	Key subcontractor (radar ASIC) sole-source; no second source qualified	4 / 5 / 20	HIGH	Qualify alternate supplier by CDR; hold 3% MR	CO / COR
R-002	Software TRL 5 at MS B; target TRL 7 by PDR not achieved	3 / 4 / 12	HIGH	Add 6-week software sprint; daily stand-up with SE	PM / SE
R-003	O&M funds may be swept in CR; test range unavailable	3 / 3 / 9	MED	Identify alternate test window; brief FM on funding risk	FM / PM
R-004	Key engineer departure risk (2 staff eligible for retirement)	2 / 4 / 8	MED	Knowledge transfer plan; retention bonus request to HR	Deputy PM
R-005	Minor supplier late delivery on non-critical hardware	2 / 2 / 4	LOW	Monitor via DCMA weekly report; no action required	COR

The Risk Management Cycle

- **Identify:** Brainstorm risks across technical, cost, schedule, and programmatic domains
- **Analyze:** Assess probability (1-5) and impact (1-5) for each risk, cost and schedule
- **Plan:** Develop mitigation strategies, owners, and timelines for high/medium risks
- **Track:** Update risk register monthly; show burn-down trends at program reviews
- **Control:** Execute mitigation actions, retire closed risks, elevate emerging risks
- **Opportunities:** Actively manage positive risks (early tech maturation, cost savings)

CATEGORY	DEFINITION	MANAGEMENT ACTION
Risk	A potential future adverse event	Mitigate: reduce probability or impact before it occurs
Issue	A risk that has materialized	Resolve: develop corrective action plan immediately
Opportunity	A potential future positive event	Exploit, enhance, share, or accept the benefit

Running an Effective Risk Review Board

Mid-career PMs who run Risk Review Boards (RRBs) must transform the risk register from a compliance document into a decision-making tool. Common failure modes: risks rated identically month after month with no change in status; risk owners who attend RRBs without new data; mitigation plans with due dates perpetually pushed out. Fix this with three disciplines: (1) require each risk owner to bring updated probability and impact ratings with data justification (“I still rate this 3×3 because nothing has changed” is not acceptable; (2) close

risks that have been mitigated with documented evidence; (3) escalate risks that haven't moved in 90 days) either they're not real risks, or they're not being worked. (A risk register that reads the same in month six as it did in month one isn't a risk register, it's a diary entry that says "today was fine" on repeat.) A 15-risk register where all 15 are "being monitored" is a risk register that has failed.

Opportunity Management and Risk Retirement: The Senior PM's Discipline

Senior PMs manage both risk AND opportunity: the asymmetric upside that is often neglected in risk-focused cultures. An opportunity is an event that, if it occurs, would reduce cost, accelerate schedule, or improve performance. Examples: a technology maturation faster than planned that allows an earlier CDR; a competitor's contract performance failure that opens a sole-source opportunity; a congressional add that funds an accelerated production ramp. Opportunities require the same rigor as risks: owner, probability, value, exploitation plan, and trigger event. Senior PMs also understand risk retirement: when a risk's trigger date has passed without occurrence, formally close it and release the associated Management Reserve. Programs that never retire risks over-hold Management Reserve and underreport program health.

Key Terms

Risk Register

A documented log of identified risks including probability, impact, and mitigation plans.

Risk Mitigation

Actions taken to reduce the probability or impact of a risk.

Opportunity Management

Actively exploiting positive events to improve program outcomes.

MR

Management Reserve: budget set aside to address identified and unforeseen risks.

UB

Undistributed Budget: budget that has not yet been assigned to specific work packages.

Risk Burn-down

Tracking risk probability and impact over time as mitigation actions are executed.

PROGRAM OPERATIONS & LEADERSHIP · LESSON 3

Stakeholder Management & Executive Communication

13 min

Build the relationships and communication skills that separate effective PMs from mere managers.

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Key Stakeholders

- **Program Executive Officer (PEO):** Your direct superior; manages your portfolio and fights for your resources
- **Service Acquisition Executive (SAE):** Delegated authority over all acquisition programs for the Service
- **USD(A&S):** Ultimate DoD acquisition authority; sees ACAT I programs at milestone reviews
- **Program Office Team:** Engineers, logisticians, financial managers, contracting officers, CORs
- **Combatant Commands:** The warfighters who will use the system: their requirements drive everything
- **Congressional Staff:** Monitors programs on their committees; a single staffer can affect funding
- **Contractors:** Partners in program execution; relationship management is critical
- **OSD Cost / CAPE:** Independent cost analysis; often skeptical of program office estimates

Program Review Battle Rhythm

REVIEW	PURPOSE	AUDIENCE	TYPICAL CADENCE
Monthly Status Review (MSR)	Program health update: cost, schedule, performance, risk	PEO / PM	Monthly
System Requirements Review (SRR)	Validate system requirements are complete and feasible	IPT, PEO	Once (Phase A)
Preliminary Design Review (PDR)	Validate system design satisfies all requirements	IPT, PEO, ACAT I: DAB	Once (Phase B)
Critical Design Review (CDR)	Validate detailed design is mature enough to build	IPT, PEO, ACAT I: DAB	Once (Phase C)
Test Readiness Review (TRR)	Confirm system is ready for developmental testing	IPT, OT&E office	Pre-test events
Defense Acquisition Board (DAB)	Milestone decisions for ACAT I programs	USD(A&S)	At each milestone

Managing Up: Briefing Flag Officers and SES Officials

Mid-career PMs who brief flag officers and SES officials must master a different communication register than the one they use with their team. Three rules for flag-level briefings: (1) State the problem in the first 30 seconds, senior leaders do not have patience for context-building before the issue (they want the trailer, not the director's cut); (2) Present no more than three options with a clear recommendation, decision makers who are given seven options with no recommendation will make no decision; (3) Know the difference between informing and deciding, some briefings are status updates, some require a decision. Be explicit about which one you're presenting. The most common mid-career failure: walking into a flag-level review to "provide an update" and leaving with no decision when a decision was urgently needed. Prepare your ask in advance.

Congressional Liaison: Protecting Your Program Through the Hill

Senior PMs on major programs interact with congressional staff, whether they realize it or not. The rules: (1) all congressional communications go through your legislative liaison office, never independently contact a congressional office; (2) Congressional Budget Justification Books (CBB) are your primary public narrative, invest in them as carefully as you invest in milestone briefings, because Hill staffers read them; (3) Classified program briefs to HASC/SASC staff are opportunities to build program support, use them; (4) if your program receives a congressional mark (reduction, add, or fence), understand what drove it, usually either a performance concern that surfaced publicly or a constituent interest. Fix the performance concern; support the constituent

interest where it aligns with program needs. A little relationship maintenance up front is a lot cheaper than a surprised phone call from a staffer during markup season. Programs with strong Hill relationships consistently outperform programs that ignore Congress.

Key Terms

DAB

Defense Acquisition Board (yet another “Defense” in the acronym soup; at this point we’re just counting): OSD-level review for major programs at milestone decisions.

IPT

Integrated Product Team: a cross-functional team responsible for a specific area of the program.

OIPT

Overarching Integrated Product Team: senior-level IPT that resolves cross-functional issues.

PEO

Program Executive Officer: the management layer between the PM and the Service Acquisition Executive.

SAE

Service Acquisition Executive: the senior acquisition official for each Military Department.

PROGRAM OPERATIONS & LEADERSHIP · LESSON 4

Subcontractor Management in Defense Programs

16 min

Understand what it actually means for a prime contractor to manage its subcontractors, and what changes when a sub goes silent, gets acquired, or breaks a clause.

Understand what it actually means for a prime contractor to manage its subcontractors, and what changes when a sub goes silent, gets acquired, or breaks a clause.

What Does “Manage” a Subcontractor Actually Mean?

- Identification of critical subcontractors and the make/buy strategy
- Subcontract surveillance approach: how the prime monitors each major sub
- Frequency and format of subcontractor performance reviews
- Flow-down clause requirements applicable to each subcontract tier
- Corrective action process when a subcontractor misses performance milestones
- Government insight mechanisms: data rights, audit access, review participation
- Small business subcontracting plan goals and tracking methodology

The Sub Goes Silent. Now What?

CLAUSE	REQUIREMENT	APPLIES TO
DFARS 252.204-7012	Safeguarding Covered Defense Information & Cyber Incident Reporting	All subs handling CDI/CUI
DFARS 252.246-7007	Contractor Counterfeit Electronic Parts Detection & Avoidance	Electronic parts subcontracts
DFARS 252.225-7009	Restriction on Acquisition of Certain Articles Containing Specialty Metals	Applicable subs with specialty metals
FAR 52.219-9	Small Business Subcontracting Plan	Large business prime > \$750K threshold
FAR 52.222-26	Equal Opportunity clause	Most subcontracts > \$10K
DFARS 252.244-7001	Contractor Purchasing System Administration	Cost-reimbursable contracts

SUBCONTRACT TYPE	GOVERNMENT VISIBILITY	KEY OVERSIGHT MECHANISM
Major subcontract (> \$25M)	High: prime required to provide performance data; DCMA may conduct independent reviews	Monthly sub-IPT reviews, CPSR, IPMR Format 2
Critical path subcontract	High: regardless of dollar value; drives program schedule	Schedule variance reporting, TRR participation
Commercial item subcontract	Limited: commercial pricing protections restrict insight	Prime certification of price reasonableness
Small business subcontract	Moderate: tracked via SF-294/295 reporting	Subcontracting plan annual reports, eSRS
COTS subcontract	Low: treated as catalog purchase	Prime incoming inspection, delivery confirmation

The Corrective Action Escalation Path

- Step 1:** Identify the issue through prime reporting or DCMA surveillance: document in writing
- Step 2:** Direct the prime PM (not the subcontractor directly) to develop a corrective action plan (CAP)
- Step 3:** Set a hard CAP review deadline: 30 days maximum for critical issues
- Step 4:** Assess the CAP's adequacy; if insufficient, escalate to the prime's senior management via the CO
- Step 5:** If non-performance continues, the CO may issue a formal cure notice or show-cause letter, and in serious cases, the subcontract may need to be terminated. These are serious contractual actions that must be

coordinated with legal counsel and the CO. Once issued, they cannot be easily walked back: they should be used deliberately, not as threats. This isn't the contracting equivalent of threatening to turn the car around from the front seat. If you say it, mean it.

6. **Step 6:** Consult with legal and CO on contract remedies if the pattern of non-performance continues

Managing Subcontractor Risk on Complex Defense Programs

Mid-career PMs on programs with significant subcontractor content must build government visibility into the subcontract tier: not just rely on the prime's reporting. Best practices: (1) require the prime's EVM system to include subcontractor EVM data for subcontracts over \$20M (this is contractually required on programs with EVMS requirements); (2) attend quarterly subcontractor program reviews with the prime: as an observer, not a participant, to avoid a privity-of-contract issue; (3) include a subcontractor management section in the prime's Format 2 IPMR submissions so you can identify which organizational elements are driving variance. Treat that sentence with the same skepticism you'd give a teenager who insists the bedroom is "basically clean." When a prime says "we have a subcontractor problem but we're managing it," your question should be: "show me the corrective action plan and the sub's EVM data."

Privity of Contract, Novation, and Corporate Transactions: When Your Contractor Changes

Senior PMs must understand what happens when their contractor is acquired, merges, or undergoes a corporate restructuring. The government has no contractual relationship with subcontractors (privity of contract); all rights run through the prime. When a prime is acquired: FAR 42.1200 requires a novation agreement: the government must consent to transfer of the contract to the successor entity. Without government consent, contract performance by the new entity is a contract violation. The novation process takes 60-180 days; during that window, the contractor is technically in breach. Manage this proactively: when you learn of a pending M&A transaction affecting your contractor, initiate the novation process immediately and get legal counsel involved. Corporate transactions also frequently trigger key personnel departures: require the prime to brief you on retention plans for key personnel before the acquisition closes.

Key Terms

SMP

Subcontract Management Plan: a document detailing how the prime contractor will manage and oversee its subcontractors.

Flow-Down Clauses

FAR/DFARS contract clauses that the prime is required to include in its subcontracts.

Consent to Subcontract

Government approval required before a prime can award certain subcontracts on cost-reimbursable contracts.

DFARS 252.244-7001

The DFARS clause requiring contractor compliance with approved purchasing system requirements.

DCMA

Defense Contract Management Agency (the “Defense” count for this module is getting a little embarrassing): provides contract administration and oversight services for DoD.

Small Business Subcontracting Plan

Required plan (FAR 52.219-9) for large contractors to maximize subcontracting to small businesses.

PROGRAM OPERATIONS & LEADERSHIP · LESSON 5

5 Most Common Mistakes New Program Managers Make

16 min

The five failure patterns that define struggling defense program managers, drawn from real acquisition programs.

The Steepest Learning Curve in Government Service

The transition into a program manager role is one of the steepest learning curves in government service. The technical knowledge, regulatory familiarity, and stakeholder management skills required are immense, and there is rarely enough time to develop them through formal training alone before the first milestone review arrives. The five patterns below appear across programs of all sizes and services. They are not obscure edge cases. They are the default failure mode when a PM hasn't been explicitly warned.

Mistake #1: Treating the IMS as a Reporting Tool, Not a Management Tool

New PMs often inherit an Integrated Master Schedule that their predecessor built primarily to satisfy oversight reporting requirements. The IMS becomes a static document updated before reviews rather than a living management artifact. This is a critical error. The IMS should be your primary tool for tracking program health: every work package, every dependency, every critical path relationship must reflect reality. A schedule that shows green when the program is actually amber or red doesn't protect you; it exposes you to far greater risk when the truth surfaces at a major milestone review. The truth has a way of finding the worst possible room to announce itself in, and that room usually has your PEO in the front row.

IMS Best Practices: What Effective PMs Do

- Hold weekly schedule scrubs with IPT leads: not just reviews of the summary schedule, but work package level status with responsible parties defending their dates.
- Enforce schedule discipline at the work package level. If a work package owner reports “on schedule” but their completion date has slipped, that is a red flag requiring immediate discussion.
- Never let the IMS drift more than one reporting cycle from ground truth. A single reporting period of “we’ll catch up” compounds into months of unrecoverable schedule growth.
- Maintain a separate, honest internal view alongside any externally-formatted schedule. What you brief to oversight should be accurate, but your internal working view should include all known risks and their schedule impacts before they become public.

FROM LUCAS**SFAS and the Weekly Schedule Scrub**

When I went through Special Forces Assessment and Selection in the Army, a cadre member asked our group what actually made Special Forces guys special. People guessed the obvious stuff: Sniper School, Ranger School, some badge or another. His answer stuck with me. They're special because they practice the fundamentals every single day. They have the budget and the authority to train constantly, so by the time it's a real fight, it isn't some big unfamiliar moment. It's just another day, because they've already lived that day a thousand times in training.

Run your IMS the same way. A weekly schedule scrub isn't a status meeting, it's the daily rep that makes the milestone review feel like Tuesday instead of an ambush. PMs who scrub their schedule every week walk into CDR already knowing what the room is about to tell them. PMs who only open the IMS the week before a review are relearning their own program in real time, in front of an audience.

Mistake #2: Not Knowing Your Nunn-McCurdy Thresholds in Dollar Terms

Many new PMs know Nunn-McCurdy exists but have never calculated their program's specific breach thresholds in dollar terms. This is dangerous. The Nunn-McCurdy Act requires Congressional notification when an ACAT I program's unit cost grows beyond specific thresholds: a 15% increase over the current APB baseline triggers a “significant” breach notification, while a 25% increase over the original APB baseline triggers a “critical” breach: requiring USD(A&S) certification or program termination. You should know, at any given moment, exactly how much cost growth in total dollars separates your program from each threshold. Brief your PEO on this quarterly. Never let a potential breach be a surprise to your chain of command.

Mistake #3: Misunderstanding EVM Signals

EVM is the most powerful program health diagnostic tool available to PMs, and one of the most misunderstood. New PMs often focus on SPI and CPI as standalone numbers without understanding the trend direction or the to-complete indices. A CPI of 0.92 may be acceptable if it has been trending upward for three months; the same CPI trending downward signals a fundamentally failing program. Equally important: EVM only reflects what has been authorized, budgeted, and reported by the contractor. If your EVMS surveillance is weak or your contractor's system is not DCMA-accepted, your EVM data may be telling you a story that bears no resemblance to actual program performance.

Reading EVM Signals: What to Look For

SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS	PM ACTION REQUIRED
CPI < 0.9 for 3+ consecutive periods	Systemic cost problem: will not self-correct	Initiate formal root cause analysis; brief PEO; consider EAC rebaseline
SPI < 0.9 approaching a milestone	Schedule recovery is mathematically difficult	Crash analysis (cost of accelerating); escalate to PEO; update milestone forecast
CPI trending downward even above 1.0	Early warning of emerging cost problem	Investigate before it crosses 1.0; review work package performance
TCPI > 1.10	Claimed EAC requires better efficiency than contractor has ever achieved	Reject the EAC; require a defensible bottom-up reestimate
Contractor submits same EAC for 3+ periods	EAC is a placeholder, not an analysis	Require formal EAC narrative with method documentation; escalate to DCMA

Mistake #4: Writing Vague or Untestable Requirements

Requirements are the contractual and technical foundation of your entire program. Vague requirements (those that cannot be tested, measured, or verified) create one of the most expensive failure modes in defense acquisition: requirements creep and contract disputes. New PMs often inherit CDDs and CPDs with KPPs written at a high level of abstraction, then fail to ensure those requirements are properly traced and tightened in the system specification and the contract's Statement of Work. Every KPP in your CDD should have a corresponding verification method, an acceptance threshold, and an objective value. A requirement that says the system shall be “user-friendly and robust” is not a requirement. It's a fortune cookie. If your requirements team cannot write a test procedure for a requirement, that requirement needs to be rewritten before it enters the contract.

Requirements Quality Checklist: Apply to Every KPP

- Is the requirement testable? Can you write a test procedure that would definitively confirm compliance or non-compliance? If no, the requirement is vague.
- Does the requirement have both a threshold and an objective value? Threshold = minimum acceptable; Objective = desired goal. Both must be defined.
- Is the requirement traceable from ICD/CDD through the system specification and into the contract SOW? Untraced requirements become invisible (and expensive) at CDR and PDR.
- Does the requirement state what the system must do, not how it must do it? HOW requirements constrain contractor solutions unnecessarily and invite constructive change claims when the approach doesn't work.
- Has the requirements community (JROC for ACAT I) validated that this requirement is still current, fundable, and operationally relevant? Requirements that drift from validated documents without authorization create milestone review failures.

Mistake #5: Underinvesting in Stakeholder Management

Program managers who focus exclusively on technical and contractual execution (while neglecting the human terrain of their stakeholder network) consistently struggle at milestone reviews and budget hearings. Your stakeholders include your PEO, the operational user community, the requirements community, CAPE, the Comptroller, congressional staffers, and your prime contractor's leadership. Each has different equities, different information needs, and different definitions of program success. New PMs often wait until a problem is visible before engaging upward: this is a mistake. Nobody wants to meet their PEO for the first time in the middle of a crisis; first impressions are hard enough without a burning IMS in the background. Build your stakeholder communication plan on Day 1 and treat it as seriously as your IMS.

Program Manager Stakeholder Map: Know Your Audience

STAKEHOLDER	PRIMARY CONCERN	COMMUNICATION FREQUENCY	WHAT THEY NEED FROM YOU
PEO	Portfolio health, political exposure, budget	Weekly informal + formal reviews	No surprises; honest assessments; early warning of problems
CAPE	Cost credibility, EAC realism	Milestone reviews + as needed	Defensible EACs; honest variance explanations; data access
Comptroller	Obligation rates, reprogramming risk	Monthly / quarterly	Accurate obligation forecasts; early warning of execution gaps
User Community (warfighter)	Capability delivery, fielding timeline	Program reviews + test events	Realistic fielding dates; user involvement in testing
Congressional Staffers	Cost, schedule, performance breaches	At milestones + if Nunn-McCurdy	Accurate status; no surprises before they read it elsewhere
Prime Contractor	Contract performance, EAC management	Weekly IPT + monthly formal	Clear requirements; timely decisions; EVMS credibility

The Day 1 Rule

Build your stakeholder communication plan on Day 1 of your assignment: not after your first crisis. The political capital you need during a cost or schedule problem is built during the quiet periods, through consistent, honest, proactive communication. PMs who are known to their oversight community as straight shooters who surface problems early get treated very differently during difficult reviews than those who are strangers until something goes wrong.

Key Terms

IMS

Integrated Master Schedule: the master schedule that integrates all program tasks, dependencies, and critical path relationships. Should be a living management tool, not a reporting artifact.

Critical Path

The sequence of dependent tasks that determines the minimum program duration. Any delay on the critical path directly delays the program end date.

Work Package

The lowest-level element of a WBS where work is planned, budgeted, and measured. IMS schedule discipline must be maintained at the work package level.

Nunn-McCurdy

The statutory cost breach notification law (10 U.S.C. § 2433). A 15% unit cost growth over the current APB triggers a “significant” breach notification to Congress; 25% over the original APB triggers a “critical” breach requiring USD(A&S) certification or program termination.

APB

Acquisition Program Baseline: the formal cost, schedule, and performance baseline approved at Milestone B. Nunn-McCurdy breach thresholds are calculated against APB values.

EVMS

Earned Value Management System: the contractor's management control system for planning, measuring, and reporting performance. Must be DCMA-accepted for ACAT I programs.

KPP

Key Performance Parameter: a threshold requirement that, if not met, may require program review and potentially a different acquisition approach. Every KPP must be testable and verifiable.

JROC

Joint Requirements Oversight Council: validates requirements for ACAT I programs. Chaired by the VCJCS; ensures requirements are joint and prioritized.

CAPE

Cost Assessment and Program Evaluation: OSD office that produces independent cost assessments. CAPE estimates are typically higher than program office estimates and are historically more accurate.

SPI

Schedule Performance Index: EV/PV . Measures schedule efficiency. Below 1.0 means schedule is behind plan; above 1.0 means ahead.

CPI

Cost Performance Index: EV/AC . Measures cost efficiency. Below 1.0 means spending more than planned for work accomplished; above 1.0 means under budget.

Knowledge Check

A program's IMS shows all tasks on schedule during a mid-point program review, but the PM privately knows several work packages are behind. What is the most significant risk of this situation?

A. The program will receive a negative DAES assessment

✓ **B. The disconnect will surface at a major milestone review, causing far greater damage than honest early reporting would have**

C. DCMA will issue a surveillance finding for inaccurate EVM reporting

D. Congressional staffers will request an independent assessment

WHY

A schedule that shows green when the program is actually amber or red doesn't protect the PM: it exposes them to far greater risk when the truth surfaces at a major milestone review. PEOs and oversight bodies are far more forgiving of honest early warnings than of surprises at milestone decision points.

An ACAT I program's original APB unit cost was \$100M. After restructuring, the current APB unit cost is \$115M. At what unit cost would a critical Nunn-McCurdy breach occur?

A. \$132.25M (25% above current APB of \$115M)

✓ **B. \$125M (25% above original APB of \$100M)**

C. \$127.5M (15% above current APB)

D. \$140M (25% above restructured baseline)

WHY

The critical Nunn-McCurdy breach threshold is calculated against the ORIGINAL APB baseline: $\$100\text{M} \times 1.25 = \125M . This catches many PMs off guard because the critical breach threshold (\$125M) is actually lower than the significant breach threshold ($\$115\text{M} \times 1.15 = \132.25M) on a restructured program.

A program's CPI has been 0.91, 0.89, and 0.87 over the past three reporting periods. What does this trend indicate?

A. Normal performance variation: single-period CPI fluctuations are expected

✓ B. A systemic cost problem that will not self-correct and requires formal PM action

C. The contractor's EVMS is not DCMA-accepted and the data is unreliable

D. The program is approaching a significant Nunn-McCurdy breach

WHY

A CPI trending downward over three consecutive periods (0.91 → 0.89 → 0.87) signals a systemic cost problem that will not self-correct. Statistical research shows that CPI rarely improves by more than 10% after the program is 20% complete. This requires formal root cause analysis, PEO briefing, and likely an EAC reestimate.

Why is a KPP that “cannot have a test procedure written for it” a problem?

A. It violates JCIDS documentation requirements for CDD submission

✓ B. It is untestable, meaning there is no way to confirm compliance or non-compliance, creating contract disputes and requirements creep

C. It requires CAPE review before it can be included in the system specification

D. It cannot be incorporated into the contract SOW under FAR guidelines

WHY

A requirement that cannot be tested cannot be definitively confirmed as met: creating one of the most expensive failure modes in defense acquisition: requirements creep and contract disputes. The contractor builds to the minimum interpretation; the government expected something more capable. Every KPP must have a verification method, threshold, and objective value.

According to the stakeholder management framework, what do PMs most commonly do wrong when problems emerge?

A. They engage CAPE too early, before internal cost analyses are complete

✓ B. They wait until a problem is visible before engaging upward, losing the political capital built through proactive communication

C. They brief the prime contractor before informing the PEO

D. They over-communicate minor issues, creating unnecessary alarm in the oversight community

WHY

New PMs typically wait until a problem is visible before engaging upward: by which point they have no accumulated political capital from proactive communication. The right approach: consistent, honest, proactive communication during quiet periods builds the trust and credibility that makes oversight bodies supportive rather than adversarial when real problems emerge.

PROGRAM OPERATIONS & LEADERSHIP · LESSON 6

CMMI: Process Maturity in Defense Contracting

18 min

Understand CMMI maturity levels, how DoD uses them in source selections and contract management, and how to verify contractor compliance.

What CMMI Actually Measures

CMMI rates how mature and disciplined a company's processes are: does the organization have repeatable, predictable methods, or is every project starting from scratch? (Level 1 organizations reinvent the wheel every Monday morning, and somehow still act surprised when it's round.) DoD cares because when spending hundreds of millions on a system, you need a contractor who can consistently deliver quality work. CMMI rates organizations on a 1–5 scale. Level 1 is chaotic and unpredictable. Level 5 is data-driven continuous improvement. ML3 is the common DoD threshold: processes are defined, documented, and followed consistently across the organization.

CMMI Maturity Levels at a Glance

LEVEL	NAME	WHAT IT MEANS	DOD RELEVANCE
ML1	Initial	Chaotic and reactive: success depends on individual heroics, not process	High risk for DoD contracts. Avoid for complex programs.
ML2	Managed	Projects are planned and tracked, but practices vary by project team	Acceptable for smaller, lower-risk efforts only
ML3	Defined	Standard processes documented and followed organization-wide, not just on best teams	Standard DoD threshold for major program support
ML4	Quantitatively Managed	Statistical process control applied: defect rates and productivity measured quantitatively	Required for some high-assurance and safety-critical programs
ML5	Optimizing	Continuous improvement institutionalized: organization systematically learns from data	Highest rigor; rare in practice

Key Facts Every PM Must Know

- CMMI Level 3 is the standard DoD threshold for major contractors
- An appraisal is NOT a certification: it is time-limited

- CMMI-DEV vs CMMI-SVC: both are used in defense
- Verify contractor CMMI claims on the PAL database
- Scope mismatch is the most common contractor compliance gap

CMMI in DoD Source Selections

CMMI appears in RFPs as either a pass/fail eligibility criterion (“Offerors must hold a current CMMI-DEV ML3 appraisal”) or as a scored evaluation factor. As a USG PM, including a CMMI requirement protects against contractors who win on paper but lack the organizational discipline to execute consistently. As a contractor, ML3 is often the price of admission for major programs, and the PAL database means you cannot fake it. Someone always finds out, and nobody wants to be the cautionary tale in next year's training slide. Understand how CMMI requirements flow from the acquisition strategy into the RFP and then into contractor monitoring.

CMMI in Contract Administration

- PMB instability can signal CMMI process breakdown: not just EVM issues
- DCMA can conduct targeted CMMI process compliance reviews
- DFARS 252.234-7002 links EVM and CMMI for software-intensive programs
- A SCAMPI A appraisal vs. SCAMPI B: only A produces an official rating

CMMI Process Area Requirements at ML3

ML3 requires 17+ process areas to be institutionalized with defined, standardized processes. The most relevant to defense program management are: Requirements Management (REQM), Requirements Development (RD), Technical Solution (TS), Configuration Management (CM), Risk Management (RSKM), Project Planning (PP), Project Monitoring and Control (PMC), Supplier Agreement Management (SAM), and Integrated Project Management (IPM). When a program is struggling, correlate the symptoms to the relevant process areas: then request DCMA review those specific PAs rather than the entire CMMI scope.

Key Terms

CMMI

Capability Maturity Model Integration: a framework for assessing and improving organizational process maturity. Developed by Carnegie Mellon's Software Engineering Institute (SEI), now maintained by the CMMI Institute (ISACA).

Maturity Level (ML)

A 1–5 rating indicating how well-defined and disciplined an organization's processes are. ML3 is the standard DoD expectation for major contractors.

Appraisal

A formal assessment of an organization's processes by a certified CMMI Lead Appraiser resulting in an official Maturity Level rating. Valid for 3 years.

PAL

Published Appraisal Results: the CMMI Institute's public database of all current official CMMI appraisals. Always verify contractor claims here.

SCAMPI

Standard CMMI Appraisal Method for Process Improvement: the formal appraisal method. Only SCAMPI Class A produces an official ML rating.

CMMI-DEV

CMMI for Development: the model variant applicable to development work: hardware, systems engineering, and software.

CMMI-SVC

CMMI for Services: the model variant applicable to service delivery: IT support, program management support, logistics.

Process Area (PA)

A specific capability domain within CMMI: e.g., Requirements Management (REQM), Risk Management (RSKM), Configuration Management (CM). ML3 requires 17+ process areas satisfied with defined, institutionalized processes.

Scope Mismatch

The most common CMMI compliance gap: a contractor holds an appraisal for one organizational unit but proposes a different unit that has no appraisal.

DFARS 252.234-7002

The DFARS EVM clause that for software-intensive programs above certain thresholds also requires contractors to maintain a current CMMI-DEV ML3+ appraisal or have an approved plan to achieve it within 24 months.

Knowledge Check

A DoD RFP states: “Offerors must demonstrate a current CMMI Maturity Level 3 appraisal.” A contractor submits proof of a SCAMPI B assessment at ML3. Is this acceptable?

A. Yes, SCAMPI B and SCAMPI A both produce official ML ratings

✓ B. No, only a SCAMPI Class A appraisal produces an official ML rating publishable in the PAL

C. Yes, SCAMPI B is acceptable for contracts below \$100M

D. Only if the SCAMPI B was conducted within the last 12 months

WHY

Only SCAMPI Class A appraisals produce official ML ratings. A contractor presenting a SCAMPI B result as evidence of ML3 compliance is misrepresenting their CMMI status. Verify all appraisal claims in the PAL database at cmmiinstitute.com/pars.

What is the most common CMMI compliance gap that government PMs discover after contract award?

A. The contractor's appraisal is older than 5 years

B. The contractor misidentified which CMMI model version they hold (v1.3 vs v2.0)

✓ C. The appraised organizational unit doesn't include the team actually performing the contract work

D. The contractor doesn't have CMMI-SVC when CMMI-DEV is required

WHY

Scope mismatch (where the appraised organizational unit does not include the team performing your contract) is the most common post-award CMMI compliance issue. Always review the appraisal certificate scope definition in the PAL, not just the ML rating.

What is the key difference between a SCAMPI A and a SCAMPI B appraisal?

A. SCAMPI A covers hardware; SCAMPI B covers software development

✓ B. Only SCAMPI A produces an official Maturity Level rating publishable in the PAL; SCAMPI B is a lighter gap-analysis assessment that does not produce an official rating

C. SCAMPI A requires government oversight; SCAMPI B is conducted independently

D. SCAMPI B replaced SCAMPI A in the CMMI v2.0 model update

WHY

Only SCAMPI Class A produces an official Maturity Level rating citable in proposals and publishable in the PAL. A contractor citing a SCAMPI B result as their CMMI level is misrepresenting their compliance status.

Your ML3-appraised contractor is showing PMB instability, budgets keep moving forward in the schedule to avoid recording negative schedule variance. What is the most appropriate CMMI-informed response?

A. Immediately report the contractor to DCMA for EVM non-compliance

✓ B. Request that DCMA conduct a CMMI process compliance review focusing on Configuration Management and Project Planning, the ML3 process areas that directly govern PMB integrity

C. Require the contractor to upgrade to CMMI ML4 as a corrective action

D. Accept the changes since the contractor holds a current ML3 appraisal

WHY

An ML3 organization must have functional Configuration Management and Project Planning process areas governing PMB integrity. PMB instability suggests post-appraisal institutionalization failure. A targeted DCMA process compliance review, not a blanket escalation, is the correct response.

Which DFARS clause links CMMI requirements to software-intensive DoD programs above certain cost thresholds?

A. DFARS 252.215-7000 (Subcontractor Cost or Pricing Data)

B. DFARS 252.242-7006 (Accounting System Administration)

✓ C. DFARS 252.234-7002 (Earned Value Management System)

D. DFARS 252.204-7012 (Safeguarding Covered Defense Information)

WHY

DFARS 252.234-7002 links EVM and CMMI for software-intensive programs, requiring ML3+ or an approved plan to achieve it. This reflects DoD's recognition that EVM reliability depends on underlying process maturity.